Twin Lanterns, Volume 2: The South Tower

The second volume of the Twin Lanterns cycle

The Example Maintainers

Example Editions

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Dedication

For the keepers of the north tower, who took over this cycle at the top of the road and never once looked back down.

Chapter 4

The Crossing

Winter closed the north road in the second week of December, and the correspondence between the towers moved to the water. The supply boat ran when the bay allowed it, which was rarely, and each crossing carried oil, bread, and sealed notes written in lantern code because neither keeper trusted the post with the weather.

The new keeper of the north tower boarded for the first crossing of the year with a suitcase, the barometer, and one hundred and nine reasons to be glad of the break in the climb.

4.1 The Middle of the Bay

Halfway across, the engine stopped, on schedule and without drama. The boatman ate a sandwich. The keeper read the barometer, which was lying, and the sky, which was not, and signalled to the south tower with a hand lantern until the engine remembered its work.

Chapter 5

The South Tower

The south tower was smaller than its twin, one hundred and four steps, and warmer by a degree the keeper attributed to stubbornness. Its keeper had kept the light for eleven years and the code book for ten, and it was her correction in the margin that turned the singing fog of the previous summer from an anomaly into a signal.

The two keepers spent one week under the same roof, comparing registers, arguing about the weather, and adding the four hundred and first signal to the code.

5.1 What the Registers Agreed On

The registers agreed on the storms, on the fog, and on the exact hour the engine of the supply boat had failed. They disagreed on everything else, and both keepers considered this the strongest possible foundation for a continuing correspondence.

Appendix A

Glossary

Lantern code - the signals the two towers exchange by shutter and lamp. Four hundred and one as of this volume; the margin corrections are canon.

The crossing - the supply boat's run between the towers when the bay allows it. Oil first, bread second, sealed notes third.

Signal 401 - the four hundred and first code entry, added after one week under the same roof. Its meaning is recorded in both registers and disagreed upon in both margins.